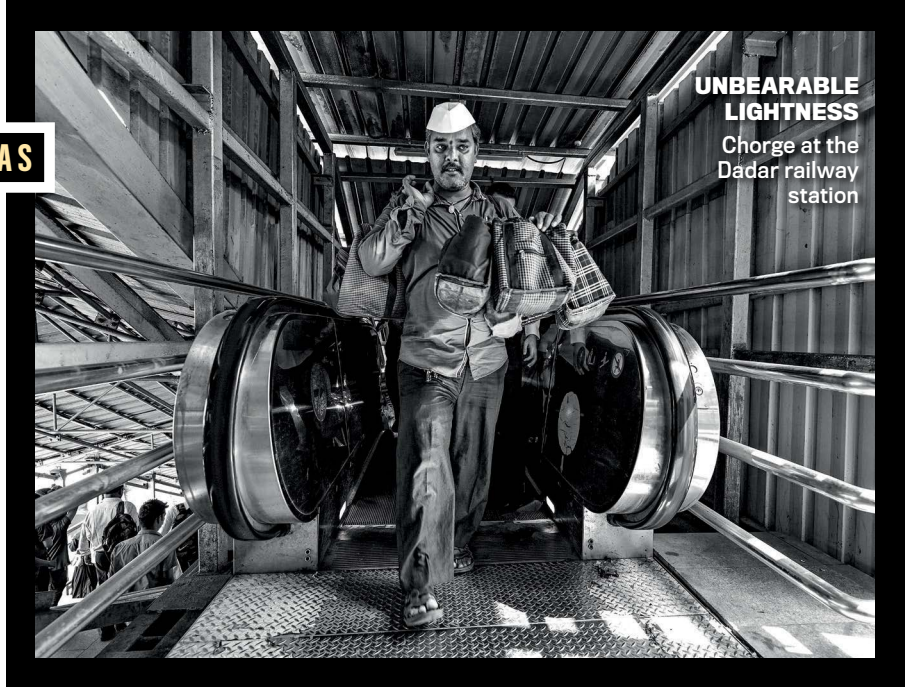


UNBEARABLE LIGHTNESS
Chorge at the Dadar railway station

Shankar Dhumal, a fourth-generation dabbawala who works the circuit around Fort and the stock exchange. Pandharinath Bacche—who services shopkeepers in the buzzing Lamington Road electronics market and offices around the Grant Road touchpoint—too, says volumes have dipped by two-thirds to around 1,000 a day. Dabbawalas? Down from 40 to just 18. The entry curbs in new office complexes, which had anyway made work tougher, came like a metaphor for a world shutting its doors on them.

So those head-mounted carriers, which could weigh a hundred kilos once loaded with the tiffin boxes, and the ubiquitous handcarts lie mothballed. And the dabbawalas are shifting to other means of livelihood. "Many of the older ones have returned to farming in their villages. The younger ones find work in industrial estates," says Vinod Shete, secretary, Nutan Mumbai Tiffin Box Suppliers Charity Trust. Kiran Gavande, general secretary, Mumbai Tiffin Box Suppliers Association, has seen many working part-time as labourers, head-load workers and security guards. Ironically, even as delivery boys for their nemeses, Swiggy and Zomato, hastening their own demise in a way. Vitthal Sawant, one such refugee from this waning business, is now a rickshaw man. Even that's an improvement. "First I had to do *mathadi* (head-load) work," he says.

Is there any chance against this gathering gloom? One ray of hope lies in the loyal clientele. Muke says there are customers who have stuck to them for decades. Some since their school days—at one time, school tiffins had come to be a big chunk of the business. Says advocate Pramod Vora, who has had lunch from his Kandivali home brought to his Fort office by dabbawalas for some 30 years: "They are unbeatable." Their publicly ascribed cultural value holds out the chance for a new niche. If the world can reformulate itself around technology, so can the dabbawalas. Ritesh Andre, 28, association spokesperson and among this vanguard, has coalesced a 'dabbawala kitchen'. For jaded city palates, its USP remains the same: home-cooked food, brought by that same 'chain gang'. Around 45 women, mostly from dabbawala households, cook in their homes, each doing 5-15 dabbas. The client base has risen to 600, presently only on the western line. "The centralised kitchen is the first initiative in the Dabbawala 4.0 project. Many more are in the pipeline...like a snacks centre," notes Andre. Kiran Gavande says a mobile app is on the way, and tie-ups with malls, stores, restaurants. In Muke's reckoning, the seed idea is good enough to extend the 'dabbawala kitchen' beyond Mumbai, even beyond Maharashtra, via local tie-ups.

Such a revitalisation, of course, needs the existing base to be secured first. Dabbawalas need dedicated parking space for their bicycles near the railway stations, luggage compartment space in air-conditioned local trains and on the metro, and space for their own housing—all long-pending demands. The community itself is now in flux. A third-generation dabbawala himself, Muke looks back wistfully at the vocational confusion education brought. "They found it difficult to get jobs or found them less remunerative. Many stayed dabbawalas to sustain their families," he says. Among their young, many looked at it as a stop-gap day job to keep the midnight oil burning. Some passed the state exams to become government servants and policemen, some even engineers and lawyers. Dhumal, who has been at the old trade for two decades, says: "The new generation is not eager to get into this. This is hard, bone-breaking work." But, in India, there's always space for it. "Around 2010-11, during the spate of farmer suicides, we offered to take on those from affected families, and a few from places like Satara joined us," notes Muke. A 'Dabbawala Bhavan' awaits inauguration in Bandra West. A museum is planned within its 3,500 sq. ft. But the dabbawalas are not planning to get museumised. Not yet. Someone, somewhere is pining for home lunch.... ■

"I am a third-generation dabbawala and have been in the profession for 16 years. Pre-Covid, I used to pick up 35 dabbas. It is just 25 now"

—VINOD CHORGE, *Dabbawala*